

2026 FUNDING GUIDE

National & State Pathways to Phone-Free Learning

How K-12 districts can fund phone-free school programs using federal, state, and local funding streams — and implement a compliant, distraction-free campus at a fraction of the cost.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- Federal funding alignment: Title I, Title IV-A, and IDEA
- State funding streams: CA, TX, NY, NJ, and beyond
- Braided funding strategies to maximize impact
- Step-by-step implementation for phone-free campuses

Federal Funding Alignment

How national programs can support your phone-free initiative

Phone-free school programs align with the goals of several major federal funding streams. Districts across the country have used these programs to support school climate, student engagement, and distraction-free learning environments. Always confirm allowability with your district's federal programs coordinator before committing funds.

Title I, Part A — Improving Basic Programs

- Supports schoolwide programs that improve academic achievement for all students
- Phone-free environments align with Title I goals of increasing instructional time and reducing classroom distraction
- Schoolwide-program campuses have flexibility to fund school climate initiatives tied to their Campus Improvement Plan

Title IV, Part A — Student Support & Academic Enrichment (SSAE)

- Explicitly funds **safe and healthy school environments** — the strongest alignment for phone-free programs
- Supports efforts to reduce bullying and cyberbullying, improve mental health, and strengthen student engagement
- SSAE block grants give districts wide discretion — phone storage solutions fit the 'safe and healthy students' priority

IDEA — Individuals with Disabilities Education Act

- Distraction-free classrooms support students with ADHD, autism, and other attention-related needs
- Phone-free environments can be written into schoolwide positive behavior supports (PBIS) frameworks

Title V — Rural and Low-Income School Program

- Rural districts can apply flexible Title V funds toward school climate and technology-management initiatives
- Smaller districts often have the most discretion in how these funds are applied

State Funding Streams

2026-27 is the largest wave of phone-free mandates — and funding — in history

More than 40 states have enacted phone restriction laws. Several pair their mandates with dedicated funding for storage solutions:

State	Mandate	Funding Pathway
California	Phone-Free School Act (AB 3216) — districts must adopt phone policies by July 1, 2026	LCFF supplemental funds; district general funds; Title IV-A alignment
Texas	HB 1481 — prohibits student phone use during the school day	TEA compliance funding guidance; district safety allotments
New York	Statewide bell-to-bell distraction-free schools requirement	\$13.5M statewide fund dedicated to phone storage solutions
New Jersey	Statewide phone-free policy push	Phone-Free Schools Grant program for storage purchases
Georgia	Distraction-Free Education Act (K-8 mandate, 2026-27)	District safety funds; Title IV-A alignment
Kansas / Michigan	Statewide restrictions effective 2026-27	District general funds; federal braiding strategies

Funding amounts and eligibility change frequently. Check your state education agency's website for current grant cycles and application deadlines.

Braided Funding: Combining Streams for Maximum Impact

Most districts fund phone-free programs by **braiding** multiple sources rather than relying on a single budget line:

- **Federal + State:** Use Title IV-A for program costs while state grants cover physical storage purchases
- **Safety budgets:** Many districts classify phone management under existing school-safety allocations
- **PTA / Foundation support:** Parent organizations frequently co-fund pilot programs at individual campuses
- **Pilot-then-scale:** Fund a single-campus pilot from discretionary funds, then apply for larger grants with pilot data in hand

Key Considerations for Braided Funding

- **Tracking:** Each funding source must be tracked and accounted for separately
- **Supplement, not supplant:** Federal funds must add to — not replace — existing district spending
- **Coordination:** Loop in your business office early; approval is faster when finance is at the table from day one

Implementation Roadmap

From policy to phone-free campus in five steps

1. Adopt Your Policy

Board-approved policy defining when devices are stored (bell-to-bell vs. class-time only), exemptions (IEP/504, medical), and enforcement procedures. Most state mandates require this step by a statutory deadline.

2. Identify Your Funding Path

Match your program to the streams in this guide. Request a consult with your federal programs coordinator and business office. Document the alignment in writing for audit purposes.

3. Pilot at One Campus

Start with a single school — ideally one with an engaged principal. A 6-12 week pilot generates the discipline, engagement, and academic data that unlocks district-wide funding.

4. Procure Your Storage Solution

For purchases under your state's competitive bidding threshold (approx. \$50K in TX, \$119K in CA), districts can buy directly without a formal RFP — dramatically faster for pilots and single-campus rollouts.

5. Train Staff & Launch

Communicate with families 2-3 weeks before launch. Train front-office staff on exemption workflows. Consistency in the first 10 school days determines the success of the entire program.

What Districts Report After Going Phone-Free

- Increased student engagement and participation in class
- Fewer behavioral referrals tied to social media conflict during school hours
- More face-to-face interaction at lunch and passing periods
- Teachers reclaiming instructional time previously lost to device management

Why Districts Choose SafePouch

Compliance without the premium price tag

SafePouch is a magnetic-locking phone pouch designed for K-12 phone-free programs. Students keep possession of their phones — secured and out of sight — eliminating the need for lockers, collection bins, or front-office storage.

	SafePouch	Typical Competitors
Price per pouch	\$18	\$25–30+
Locking mechanism	Magnetic lock — tamper-tested against neodymium magnet attacks and impact	Magnetic locks defeated by consumer magnets; zipper pouches defeated with a pencil
Cost for 5,000 students	\$90,000	\$125,000–150,000
Procurement	Under most state direct-purchase thresholds for single-campus and pilot orders	Often requires full RFP process
Student possession	Yes — no lockers, bins, or collection logistics	Varies

The Budget Math

For a 5,000-student district, SafePouch's \$18 price point saves **\$35,000–60,000** versus leading alternatives — enough to fund replacement pouches for years, or redirect savings to other safety priorities. For districts using state storage funds (like New York's \$13.5M program), lower per-unit cost means covering more students with the same grant dollars.

Get Started

- **Free samples:** We ship complimentary sample pouches to any district evaluating phone-free solutions
- **Pilot pricing:** Single-campus pilot programs available with fast turnaround
- **Funding support:** We'll help you map your program to the funding streams in this guide

SAFEPOUCH
Phone-Free Learning Solutions

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This guide is provided for informational purposes. Funding eligibility, allowability, and grant availability vary by state, district, and year. Districts should verify all funding decisions with their federal programs coordinator, business office, and legal counsel.